



Python Lists vs Sets vs Tuples

Data with Dylan | Cheat Sheet | Python Fundamentals #4

WHAT ARE LISTS, SETS & TUPLES?

Collections store multiple values inside one variable, but each collection follows different rules.

💡 Think of a list as an editable playlist, a set as a bag of unique items, and a tuple as a sealed coordinate pair.

CORE DATA & FEATURES

COLLECTION TYPE	SYNTAX EXAMPLE	MUTABLE? (YES/NO)	ORDERED? (YES/NO)	ALLOWS DUPLICATES?	BEST USED FOR
List	<code>["red", "blue"]</code>	Yes	Yes	Yes	Editable sequences that need indexing or a meaningful order.
Set	<code>{"red", "blue"}</code>	Yes	No	No	Unique values, removing duplicates, and fast membership checks.
Tuple	<code>(10, 20)</code>	No	Yes	Yes	Fixed records or coordinates that should not change.

KEY SYNTAX & OPERATIONS

Access ordered items

```
colors = ["red", "blue", "green"]
colors[0]      # -> "red"
point = (10, 20)
point[1]       # -> 20
```

Add or change mutable collections

```
colors.append("yellow")
colors[1] = "navy"
fruits.add("orange")
fruits.remove("banana")
```

Convert between collection types

```
unique = set([1, 1, 2]) # -> {1, 2}
fixed = tuple([1, 2])  # -> (1, 2)
again = list(fixed)    # -> [1, 2]
```

TYPE & FORMATTING WARNINGS

- ⚠️ {} creates a dictionary; use set() for an empty set.
- ⚠️ (5) is an integer; (5,) is a one-item tuple.
- ⚠️ Sets cannot be indexed, and their displayed order may change.
- ⚠️ True equals 1, so a set may treat them as duplicates.

MINI PRACTICE

- Choose the best collection:
- A. Unique user IDs with duplicates removed
 - B. Fixed (x, y) coordinates
 - C. An editable sequence of tasks

Hint: set, tuple, list - then try set([101, 101, 205]).

SET & TUPLE BEHAVIOR

Membership, length, and duplicate removal

```
fruits = {"apple", "banana"}
"apple" in fruits # -> True
len({"apple", "apple"}) # -> 1
len({1, True, 2}) # -> 2
```

Build a new tuple instead of changing one

```
original = (1, 2, 3)
extra = (4, 5)
updated = original + extra
# -> (1, 2, 3, 4, 5)
```

COMMON BEGINNER MISTAKES

- ❌ **Indexing a set**
`fruits[0]` # TypeError
- ✅ **"apple" in fruits** # membership check
- ❌ **Creating an empty set**
`items = {}` # this is a dict
- ✅ **items = set()**
- ❌ **Forgetting the tuple comma**
`single = ("apple")` # string
- ✅ **single = ("apple",)**
- ❌ **Changing a tuple item**
`point[0] = 5` # TypeError
- ✅ **point = (5, point[1])**